

Greater Than These Shall You Do

Stubbornness Became Useful When God Joined It to the Born-Again Trail

Romans 8:11 was one of the last verses in the chapter to go down for me. I was raised in strong Pentecostal circles, and I had preached that verse as the Holy Spirit quickening the mortal body.

When God commissioned me to come to Tulsa, He told me to go as far into God as I could, pull out the miraculous, and receive an outpouring for Him. I did not know what He was doing to me. Tulsa was full of people who knew everything, and I was not ready for what I ran into.

Eventually, as I prayed, He said I had taken other people's sheep as far as I could take them. Unless leadership went into prayer, the people would only go so far.

I tried to run from what He was asking: Phoenix, Atlanta, Florida. But the closer I got to leaving, the more I felt I would die. Finally, I obeyed.

One day in prayer I found out the attribute He wanted most from me was not what I thought. It was stubbornness. He knew this would take a while. He could use a stubborn man who knew enough truth to stay in there while He produced the born-again trail.

The Born-Again Trail Opened the Freedom Hidden in Romans 8

When God gave me the vision and I looked down the born-again trail, I lost track of time. Revelation began speaking inside me, and He said everything I was believing for was on that trail. Everything the Word says I can have, I can have if I understand this.

That first glimpse opened verses that had been locked.

For a while, I could not boldly say that the first mention of the Holy Spirit in Romans 8 was verse 16:

"The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit,
that we are the children of God."

The second mention is verse 26:

"Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities."

Why "also"? Because something else has already helped: the new nature. The Holy Spirit adds His help to the freedom you already received when you were born again.

Romans 8 before verse 16 is primarily unfolding the freedom of the born-again human spirit.

Romans 8:11 Must Be Read Through Verses 9 and 10

Romans 8:11 says:

"But if the Spirit of him that raised up Jesus from the dead dwell in you,
he that raised up Christ from the dead
shall also quicken your mortal bodies
by his Spirit that dwelleth in you."

To understand verse 11, you have to understand verses 9 and 10.

Romans 8 begins:

"There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus,
who walk not after the flesh,
but after the Spirit."

Paul stands between the covenant with Abraham and sonship and argues why we are free. "After the flesh" points back to Romans 7:5, the spiritually dead man under law:

"For when we were in the flesh,
the motions of sins, which were by the law,
did work in our members to bring forth fruit unto death."

The law set sin in motion. It exposed the spiritual death inherited from Adam.

The Law of the Spirit of Life Is the Born-Again Nature

Romans 8:2 says:

"For the law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus
hath made me free from the law of sin and death."

The Spirit of life is the born-again human spirit. The law of the new nature set me free from the law of sin and death that reigned through the old nature.

Romans 8:3-4 says:

"For what the law could not do,
in that it was weak through the flesh,
God sending his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh,
and for sin,
condemned sin in the flesh:
That the righteousness of the law might be fulfilled in us,
who walk not after the flesh,
but after the Spirit."

The Ten Commandments can finally be fulfilled in us because we have the nature they described.

The Mind Finds Life Instead of Death When It Turns Inward

Romans 8:5 says:

"For they that are after the flesh do mind the things of the flesh;
but they that are after the Spirit the things of the Spirit."

The spiritually dead man turned inward for help and found spiritual death. His mind became captive to the nature of sin.

The born-again man turns inward and finds life. His mind meets the new nature and is infused with life. That new nature says, "You do not have to sin."

This is why worship and praying in the Holy Ghost change your life. At first, when learning faith carnally, people dream of things. But as God gets hold of you, you begin to want what He wants: people saved, His plan, His life.

Carnal Mindedness Is the Mind Captive to Death

Romans 8:6-8 says:

"For to be carnally minded is death;
but to be spiritually minded is life and peace.
Because the carnal mind is enmity against God:
for it is not subject to the law of God,
neither indeed can be.
So then they that are in the flesh cannot please God."

The carnal mind is the mind ruled by spiritual death. It cannot be subject to the law of God. Romans 7 ends with the Jew serving the law of God with the mind, but the law of sin with the flesh. Romans 8 answers that dilemma.

There is therefore now no condemnation for the born-again man. The condemning sentence under the law cannot be carried out in him anymore.

The Door Is the Spiritually Alive Savior, Not a Dead Gene Pool

Jesus said no one can climb up another way. He is the door of the sheep.

That means no spiritually dead man can provide salvation out of the spiritually dead gene pool. Any man who climbs up another way is a thief and robber because he offers life he does not have.

Jesus also said:

"My sheep hear my voice,
and a stranger they will not follow."

The voice He is speaking of is not merely denominational recognition. It is the witness of the new nature and sonship. His Spirit bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God. That born-again life is the voice of the Shepherd in us.

The Father Showed the Son the Greater Work of Quickening the Dead

John 5:19-21 says:

"The Son can do nothing of himself,
but what he seeth the Father do...
For the Father loveth the Son,
and sheweth him all things that himself doeth:
and he will shew him greater works than these,
that ye may marvel.
For as the Father raiseth up the dead,
and quickeneth them;
even so the Son quickeneth whom he will."

Jesus had just healed the man who had been infirm thirty-eight years. The Father would show Him greater works than that.

What greater work? The Father raises and quickens the Son, and the Son quickens whom He will.

John 5:26 says:

"For as the Father hath life in himself;
so hath he given to the Son to have life in himself."

The Father gave life to the Son in His humanity. Then the Son gives life to those He wills. That is the new birth.

Romans 8:11 Is the Life That Raised Christ Now Quickening Us

If the Spirit of Him that raised Jesus from the dead dwells in you, then the same life the Father gave the Son now dwells in your born-again spirit.

The Father breathed life into Christ's human spirit when He quickened Him from death to life. The Son turned around and quickened you. The same life now supplies the infusion you need so your mind no longer serves spiritual death.

That is why Romans 8:12 says:

"Therefore, brethren,
we are debtors,
not to the flesh,
to live after the flesh."

The debt was canceled. Sin was canceled. Disease, poverty, and lack of peace were canceled in their root because the law of life entered your spirit.

Greater Than These Is the New Birth, Not Merely More Miracles

John 14:12 says:

"He that believeth on me,
the works that I do shall he do also;
and greater works than these shall he do;
because I go unto my Father."

The word "works" after "greater" is supplied in italics. Jesus says the works He did, you will do also, and greater than these you will do because He goes to the Father.

What happened when He went to the Father? The greater work became available. Old Testament saints and prophets saw miracles, healings, and mighty works. But they could not get anyone born again.

Now we are able ministers of the New Testament, not of the letter but of the spirit. We minister the greater work: preaching the gospel so the Spirit of life can make men born again.

The Able Minister of the Spirit Carries the Greatest Work

The greater work is not merely a larger miracle count. It is the new birth.

When you preach this gospel, God performs the miracle. You have the privilege of administering grace for the born-again experience as an able minister of the spirit.

Jesus went to the Father, and the life that was in Him became the life in us. Now we can minister that life to others through the gospel.

That is greater than anything the Old Testament could produce.